

## Mountlake Terrace cancels Flock Safety contract

Published 10:26 am Friday, December 5, 2025

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EVERETT — The Mountlake Terrace City Council unanimously voted to end the city’s contract with Flock Safety on Thursday, citing community division and public records concerns.

In June, the council voted 5-2 to enter a \$54,000 contract with the automated license plate reader company following public pushback. The city will still have to pay Flock \$27,000 for the first year of the two-year contract.

Over the past several months, community concerns have grown over the misuse of Flock technology.

Recent reports from The Daily Herald and the University of Washington revealed federal agencies — including U.S. Border Patrol and Homeland Security Investigations — gained access to multiple Flock networks in Snohomish County, often without police departments knowing. Out-of-state law enforcement agencies searched local Flock data for reasons directly related to immigration or seemingly on behalf of U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement, which could violate state law.

Flock Safety cameras are automated license plate readers that use artificial intelligence to analyze vehicle footage. Many law enforcement agencies across the country have implemented the technology as an investigative tool to help locate stolen vehicles and missing persons.

On Thursday, Mountlake Terrace Mayor Pro Tem Bryan Wahl made the motion to cancel the contract. He said many council members originally supported Flock after hearing success stories from other cities in the county.

“We adopted it with the intent of improving public safety, but since then we have seen that it has been weaponized against cities and their residents and brought great division to our community,” Wahl said.

The city hadn't yet installed its Flock cameras. In September, City Manager Jeff Niten said the city was waiting for the outcome of a public records case in Skagit County Superior Court. In July, the cities of Stanwood and Sedro-Woolley sought a judgment that Flock footage was not subject to public records requests. Last month, a judge denied to make the judgment, effectively ruling that Flock footage is public record. Stanwood and Sedro-Woolley are now appealing the decision. The city of Everett is seeking a similar judgment in Snohomish County Superior Court.

Many cities in Washington — including Lynnwood, Stanwood, Redmond and Olympia — have paused or suspended their Flock camera networks. Mountlake Terrace appears to be the first city in the state to cancel its contract completely.

“Council acknowledges and appreciates the opinions expressed by the community over the last several months,” Niten said in a statement Friday. “The City has been listening. The voices of residents played a part in this final decision, along with many other city, state, and nation-wide factors.”

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